



What better way to show your better half how much you love him or her than by putting their picture on your desktop? You'll need to know how to use a scanner, of course. No sweat. Place the desired picture on the scanner glass, push a single button without even starting a software, and hey presto—the picture's scanned and ready to be put up as your new wallpaper!

Scanners have become so readily available, and user-friendly that almost anybody can use them. They've become a great multipurpose tool for the office and the studio. From enhancing Web sites to digital data management, scanners make it all possible.

Scanners have become popular because people like to digitise the analogue life we live—the average person wants a colour scanner for photos, graphics, or plain document scanning. A small to medium business enterprise might look for a scanner that can do fast black-and-white scanning, which can later be OCR-ed into editable text. Graphic artists or desktop publishers—and professional imaging studios—might seek an ultra high-end, specialised, feature-packed photo scanner.

But how do you go about choosing a scanner? Is a 36-bit scanner better than a 48-bit scanner? What about resolution? Do you need 600-dpi (dots per inch) or will 300-dpi be sufficient?

Well, most home users should find a 300 dpi scanner sufficient. However, power users need to have a minimum of 600 dpi. Speed is also another factor which you should consider. A scanner may be sleek and have support for high resolutions,

but if it scans at a snail's pace, your investment's not going to be wildly useful. Hence, before buying, always scan a document to check the speed and look for the ability to reproduce colour adequately.

Go for a USB scanner rather than one that's parallel port-based, as this will give faster speeds. Also, make sure you buy a scanner that you gives you a reasonably good image-editing and OCR software bundled with the product, so you can save some money on software. The warranty should also be carefully checked, especially whether it's 'carry in' or not.

Scanners have not really been an integral part of a regular home PC user, and the last couple of years have not seen any major technological enhancement. Most of the home and SoHo segment have been buying scanners mainly for scanning photographs, and the falling prices of digital cameras has affected this segment. The only major technological enhancement perhaps has been in the interface, where the shift has been from Small Computer System Interface (SCSI) to Parallel to USB 1.1. Of late, some scanners even ship with USB 2.0.

Entry-level scanners available in the market today cost Rs 3,500 and up. The Benq S2W 4300U and HP Scanjet 2300 are available at a rock-bottom price of around Rs 3,500. With very few players (and Epson opting out of the race) the competition in this segment is severe. Another problem with such scanners is that of heavy wear and tear during transportation, which leads to malfunctioning of devices to a great extent.

HP is the undisputed leader, with around 50 per cent marketshare. HP is followed by Canon and Umax. With all vendors understanding the market reality, the focus now is shifting towards multi-functional printers (MFPs), or AIOs (all-in-ones) as some vendors prefer to call them. The focus is to provide a low-cost solution and save precious desktop space for users.

Market indications are that low-end inkjets and scanners would be phased out over the next few months, and the home and SoHo segment are likely to go in for these multi-functional devices instead.



Buying Tips

- Select a hardware resolution depending on the kind of document you are going to scan; for example, 300 dpi is not enough if you plan to scan photographs
- Check the packaging contents and make sure that the requisite cables and connectors are included
- Check whether the vendor gives carry-in or on-site warranty—on-site warranty is a better option as the technician comes to your place for repairs
- A transparency adapter is a must if you are going to scan negatives. Also ensure that the scanner has an interface to connect the required adapter
- New scanners might have thermocol bits on their inner sides that will show up as black dots on the media scanned. Remove such particles from the scanner by wiping it with a soft cloth and make sure there are no scratches on the glass surface
- If you're scanning thick books or such, go for a scanner with a removable lid, or one where the lid can rise to a height of two inches or more
- 36-bit scanners are on their way out; 48-bit is now considered entry-level for scanners.
- A good OCR and imaging software bundled along with the scanner will not only save you additional investment, but will also extend the usability of your scanner



hp Scanjet 2300



Scan and create family albums.

